Getting Up and Running

By this point, you have a pretty good sense for what the Arduino is, its history, and some of what you can do with it. It's really exciting that with a few carefully written commands, which you will learn in the upcoming chapters, you can make things light up or move, sense the world around you, and generally make things more fun.

And now that you have some basic hardware in hand, including an Arduino interface board, it's time to get up and running. We need to do the following before moving on to the next chapter:

1. Download and install the Arduino development environment
2. Connect the Arduino board with a USB cable and install drivers
3. Launch the Arduino application and open the Blink example
4. Select your board and serial port
5. Upload your first sketch

Don't worry. It's not that difficult to get going. In fact, it's generally hard to go wrong, because it is nearly impossible to burn the house down or cut off an arm with an Arduino. And even if you wire up something wrong, it's probably okay because the Arduino board is a tough little guy and can take some abuse. So don't worry that you might mess something up. Of course, we are going to make some mistakes, but hopefully they will teach us something and we will become better programmers and makers because of it. So let's get on with it.

Installing the Software

First things first, you need to download and install the Arduino software. Because the Arduino Team is always making updates to the software, you should head to the main download page on the Arduino web site (`http://arduino.cc/en/Main/Software`), shown in Figure 1-8.